

SUKHWINDER RAJA, *44*
The Sukhwinder Raja Ministries, Daduana, Amritsar



PASTORNAMA

"A miracle changed my family's and my life"

In the last week of August, a group of Nihang Sikhs attacked Raja's Sunday congregation, agitated at what they alleged were his ministry's attempts to convert people. The attack caught the attention of Sikhs internationally after Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh supported the Nihangs. Hailing from the Sansi tribal community, Raja used to work at a local bakery before he converted to the Christian faith a decade back. He claims that prayer healed a paralytic attack that he suffered. "The miracle changed my life and that of my family," says Raja. He also recounts how Jat Sikhs had stopped his family many times from entering the local gurdwara. "They had objections to our tribal eating habits (primarily, the non-veg diet). Now, no one can judge us." Before the attack, his congregation at a rented one-acre plot would attract 100-odd people. Now, that has come to a stop. Raja hopes to buy the land one day and restart his congregations.

ment anywhere. But what he runs—the Church of Signs and Wonders—is the largest among Punjab's new Charismatic orders. A mini-empire, in fact, counting prefectures across nine districts of Punjab, besides Bihar and Bengal and global embassies in the US, Canada, Germany and one in Harrow, Greater London. Once he converted in 2008, he started life as a miracle preacher with just three followers. Now his ministry claims a global flock of 300,000—all of whom adoringly call him 'Papa', although he prefers the prefix 'Apostle'. Square that number against the 2011 census figures, which totalled Christians in Punjab at a mere 348,000, and you bump up against the hard edge of the equation—the reason why the mandarins of other religious establishments are shifting uneasily in their august seats. Fears of a demographic spike are precisely what feed the bogey that Christian conversions have become in recent years.

At least 10,000-15,000 of that flock are congregated here on this day—hundreds of motor-